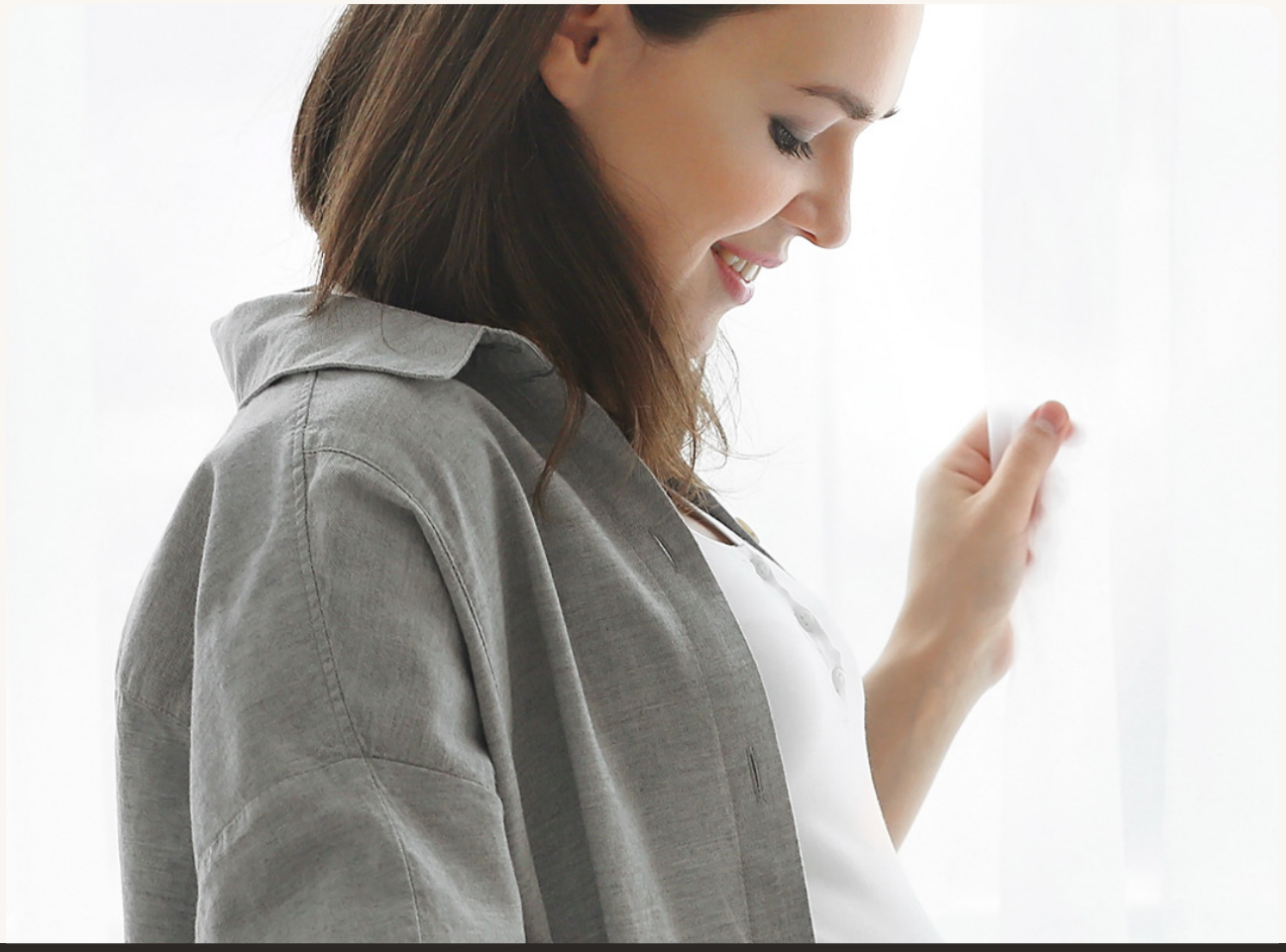
Katrina Ridout

NUTRITION

A FREE GUIDE FROM AN ACCREDITED PRACTISING DIETITIAN

Nourished

7 evidence-based nutrition foundations for fertility, pregnancy and beyond: the small number of things that genuinely matter, explained without judgement or fear.



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Less noise. More of what matters.

Take what's useful, leave what isn't, and please be kind to yourself as you go.

Whether you're trying to conceive, in the thick of pregnancy, or finding your feet as a new mum, the internet has probably handed you a hundred contradictory food rules and a fair amount of fear. This guide is the opposite of that.

I'm Katrina, an Accredited Practising Dietitian, and I work with women through fertility, pregnancy and the first couple of years of motherhood. What follows is not another list of forbidden foods. It's the handful of foundations that genuinely have good evidence behind them, written the way I'd explain them to you in a consult, each with a real example meal you could put on the table this week.

You don't need to action all seven at once. Pick the one that speaks to where you are right now, and start there. Small and consistent will always beat perfect and unsustainable.

Why you can trust this guide

The APD credential is the only nutrition qualification recognised by Medicare and most private health funds in Australia, and it requires university degree-level training, supervised practice and ongoing professional development. Every recommendation here is anchored to Australian clinical guidance (NHMRC, RANZCOG, the Royal Women's Hospital) rather than trends, with the sources listed at the back.

This guide provides general information to help you feel clearer and calmer. It is not personal medical or nutrition advice, and it does not diagnose or treat any condition. For guidance specific to your body and stage, your own dietitian, GP or specialist is the right person.

What's inside

Seven foundations, one at a time.

1 A broadly Mediterranean-style pattern is the strongest base
The one eating shape most consistently linked with better outcomes.

2 Protein at each meal does more than any single "superfood"
Steadier energy and appetite through every stage.

3 Folate and iodine are the two to get right early
Small supplements, outsized importance in the early weeks.

4 Iron is the quiet one that flattens so many women
And the simple trick that helps you absorb more of it.

5 You don't need to "eat for two"
Quality over quantity, and the pressure it takes off.

6 Nausea nutrition is damage control, not perfection
Getting something in beats getting it "right".

7 Postpartum, you are still recovering, and often feeding someone
Why under-eating works against you now.

1

THE STRONGEST BASE

A broadly Mediterranean-style pattern is the strongest base

If I could give you just one shape to hang everything else on, it would be this one. Not a diet with rules and a start date, but a flexible pattern: plenty of vegetables and legumes, whole grains, olive oil, fish a couple of times a week, and not too much ultra-processed food. It's affordable, it's forgiving, and there's no single "superfood" you have to hunt down. Think of it as a shape, **not a rulebook**.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

A Mediterranean-style pattern is the eating approach most consistently associated in research with better fertility and pregnancy outcomes, including among couples undergoing IVF, and with a lower risk of complications such as gestational diabetes and pre-eclampsia. These are associations rather than guarantees, but it is the most robust and repeated signal we have, and it aligns closely with the Australian Dietary Guidelines.

Trusted resource: Australian Dietary Guidelines : eatforhealth.gov.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Swap one meat-based dinner for a legume one, like a lentil bolognese or a chickpea curry. That single change nudges your whole week toward the pattern.



TRY THIS

Roasted carrot & grain salad, tahini dressing

Roasted carrots and chickpeas over a warm grain (freekeh, barley or brown rice), fresh herbs, a scatter of seeds, and a quick lemon-tahini dressing.

Why it works: it's the whole pattern in one bowl (vegetables, legumes, whole grains and good fats), and it keeps beautifully for lunch the next day.

2

THE QUIET WORKHORSE

Protein at each meal does more than any single "superfood"

Protein is the least glamorous thing I talk about and the one that changes how women feel the most. It steadies your energy and appetite, takes the edge off the mid-afternoon crash, and helps you feel full for longer, which matters through nausea, through treatment, and through the bone-deep tiredness of early motherhood. Most women I see are loading it all at dinner. **Spreading it across the day is the shift.**

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Protein needs rise in pregnancy. The Royal Women's Hospital suggests around three and a half serves a day of meat or alternatives (a serve is roughly 65g of cooked red meat, 100g of fish, two eggs, or a cup of legumes). A simple, practical target is a palm-sized serve at each meal. You don't need shakes or special products: eggs, yoghurt, tinned fish, chicken, tofu, legumes and nuts all count.

Trusted resource: The Royal Women's Hospital : thewomens.org.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Add a protein to breakfast tomorrow: eggs, Greek yoghurt, or peanut butter on toast. Breakfast is where most of us fall short.



TRY THIS

Tuna & white bean salad

Tinned tuna and cannellini beans through crisp leaves and tomato, red onion, parsley, olive oil and lemon. Ready in five minutes from the pantry.

Why it works: two protein sources in one bowl (fish and legumes) for a serve that actually keeps you full, plus iron and fibre along for the ride.

3

GET THESE RIGHT EARLY

Folate and iodine are the two to get right early

These two matter most in the very early weeks, often before you know the exact numbers to aim for, which is why I like women to have them sorted before or as soon as they're trying. The good news is they're simple: the right supplement plus a few everyday foods does almost all the work. **You don't have to get this perfect, you just have to get it started.**

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

In Australia, a **500 microgram folic acid supplement** is recommended from when you start planning through the first three months of pregnancy, to reduce the risk of neural tube defects, alongside folate-rich foods (leafy greens, legumes, wholegrains). A **150 microgram iodine supplement** is recommended by the NHMRC for anyone pregnant, breastfeeding or planning, to support your baby's brain development. Some women (for example with certain medical histories) need a higher folic acid dose, so your GP will confirm what's right for you.

Trusted resource: NHMRC iodine statement : nhmrc.gov.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

If you're trying or newly pregnant, check the label on your supplement: you're after 500 micrograms of folic acid and 150 micrograms of iodine.



TRY THIS

Big green salad with feta & chickpeas

Rocket and baby spinach with chickpeas, cherry tomato, olives and creamy feta, dressed with olive oil and lemon. Add a boiled egg to turn it into a full meal.

Why it works: leafy greens and chickpeas bring folate, while feta, egg and (if you use it) iodised salt add iodine. Food supports the supplement, it doesn't replace it.

4

THE QUIET ONE

Iron is the quiet one that flattens so many women

So much of the exhaustion, breathlessness and brain fog I hear about traces back to iron running low, through trying to conceive, pregnancy, and especially the postpartum months when blood loss and broken sleep collide. It's easy to write off as "just tired", but it's often fixable. **A little know-how at the plate goes a long way**, and blood tests tell us the rest.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Iron needs rise to about **27mg a day** during pregnancy (NHMRC), noticeably more than before. Pairing iron-rich foods (red meat, legumes, tofu, leafy greens) with a little vitamin C (a squeeze of lemon, some capsicum or tomato) helps your body absorb more of the iron from plants. Strong tea or coffee alongside a meal does the opposite, so it's worth keeping those between meals. Whether you need a supplement is best guided by a blood test, not guesswork.

Trusted resource: Better Health Channel : betterhealth.vic.gov.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Add a squeeze of lemon or some tomato to your next iron-rich meal, and shift your tea or coffee to between meals rather than with them.



TRY THIS

Grain bowl with salmon, greens & tomato

Wholegrains topped with salmon (or lentils and tofu for a bigger iron hit), wilted greens, cherry tomatoes, a scatter of seeds and a good squeeze of lemon.

Why it works: iron from the greens, seeds and legumes, paired with vitamin C from tomato and lemon to help your body absorb more. Save the cuppa for an hour later.

5

PERMISSION TO RELAX

You don't need to "eat for two"

This is the one that quietly takes a lot of pressure off. "Eating for two" is one of the stickiest myths in pregnancy, and it leaves a lot of women feeling they're either not doing enough or doing too much. The truth is gentler than that. **Your body is remarkably good at this**, and it's the quality of what you eat, far more than the quantity, that matters.

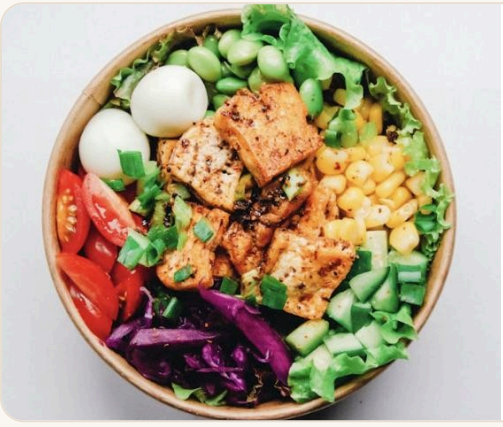
WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Both the Royal Women's Hospital and Victoria's Better Health Channel are clear that there is no need to "eat for two". Energy needs rise only modestly, and mainly later in pregnancy. As Better Health puts it, you may need more of some foods to get key nutrients, but the goal is more variety and nutrient quality, not simply more kilojoules. If you're hungrier, honour that with nourishing food; you don't need to force extra.

Trusted resource: Better Health Channel (pregnancy and diet): betterhealth.vic.gov.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Next time you plate up, build to the shape: half vegetables, a quarter protein, a quarter whole grains. Then let the quantity look after itself.



TRY THIS

A balanced "nourish" plate

Half the plate colourful vegetables, a quarter quality protein, a quarter whole grains, and a drizzle of olive oil or a few nuts or avocado for good fats.

Why it works: it's a simple template, not a calorie count. Build any meal to this shape and the quantity tends to look after itself.

6

DAMAGE CONTROL, NOT PERFECTION

Nausea nutrition is damage control, not perfection

When you're in the thick of nausea, every "eat well" message can feel like a cruel joke. So we throw the rulebook out for a while. In this season the goal is simply to get something in and stay hydrated, using whatever your body will accept. **This is not the time for perfect**, and eating plainer, beige food for a few weeks will not undo everything else you're doing.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

The classic, evidence-informed strategies are small, frequent snacks rather than big meals; dry, bland carbohydrates (crackers, dry toast) especially before getting up; and cold foods, which give off less smell. Ginger has reasonable evidence for easing mild nausea, and vitamin B6 is often recommended by clinicians as a first step. If you can't keep fluids down or are losing weight, that's a conversation to have with your GP promptly.

Trusted resource: Pregnancy, Birth & Baby : pregnancybirthbaby.org.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Keep dry crackers by the bed and eat a few before you get up. Heading off an empty stomach early often takes the edge off the whole morning.



TRY THIS

The "keep-it-down" plate

Wholegrain toast or crackers, cold fruit straight from the fridge (grapes or melon), a little cheese, and ginger tea to sip. Plain, dry and cold is exactly the aim.

Why it works: cold, dry and low-smell foods are the most tolerable when nausea is high, and grazing keeps something gently in your stomach.

7

YOU MATTER IN THIS EQUATION TOO

Postpartum, you are still recovering, and often feeding someone

The food often stops the moment the baby arrives, right when your body needs it most. You're healing, you may be breastfeeding, and you're running on interrupted sleep, yet meals become whatever can be eaten with one hand between feeds. Under-eating in these months is incredibly common, and it works against your energy, your mood and your recovery. **Feeding yourself is not indulgence right now. It's part of caring for your baby.**

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

Breastfeeding raises your energy and fluid needs above pregnancy, and Dietitians Australia recommends continuing a nutritious, varied diet (and your supplement) while feeding. The most useful move is to make good food easy: prepared-ahead meals, a stocked freezer, and a drink and a one-handed snack always within reach. This is one of the highest-value things a partner or visitor can help with.

Trusted resources: Dietitians Australia : dietitiansaustralia.org.au · Australian Breastfeeding Association : breastfeeding.asn.au

ONE SMALL STEP THIS WEEK

Make one thing ahead this week, a soup or a tray of oat jars, so future-you has a meal waiting on the hardest days. Let someone help.



TRY THIS

Big-batch oats, warm or overnight

Rolled oats cooked or soaked with milk, berries, grated apple, a scatter of nuts and a spoon of nut butter. Make extra and reheat, or keep cold jars in the fridge.

Why it works: nourishing, mostly one-handed, and it delivers protein, fibre, iron and fluids in the exact moments you'd otherwise skip a meal.

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Notice what's *missing* from these pages.

No fear. No guilt. No forbidden-food lists. None of those help you, and most of them aren't backed by good evidence anyway. What actually moves the needle is the calm, repeatable pattern you've just read, and being a little kinder to yourself than the internet tells you to be.

not fear *not guilt* *not perfect*

Evidence & trusted resources

Everything here traces back to Australian clinical guidance. Explore it yourself.

NHMRC: Iodine supplementation for pregnant and breastfeeding women

nhmrc.gov.au/about-us/publications/iodine-supplementation-pregnant-and-breastfeeding-women

The national recommendation for a 150 microgram daily iodine supplement (Foundation 3).

The Royal Women's Hospital: Food & nutrition in pregnancy

thewomens.org.au/health-information/pregnancy-and-birth/a-healthy-pregnancy/food-nutrition-in-pregnancy

Protein serves, folate and iodine, and the "eat more variety, not more food" message (Foundations 2, 3, 5).

Better Health Channel: Pregnancy and diet

betterhealth.vic.gov.au/health/healthyliving/pregnancy-and-diet

Iron (27mg/day), folate, iodine and the "no need to eat for two" guidance (Foundations 4, 5).

Australian Dietary Guidelines (Eat for Health, NHMRC)

eatforhealth.gov.au

The national basis for the Mediterranean-style, whole-food pattern (Foundation 1).

Pregnancy, Birth & Baby (healthdirect)

pregnancybirthbaby.org.au

Government-funded guidance on morning sickness and nausea management (Foundation 6).

Dietitians Australia: Pregnancy & breastfeeding

dietitiansaustralia.org.au/health-advice/pregnancy-and-breastfeeding

Peak-body advice on eating well through pregnancy and while breastfeeding (Foundation 7).

Australian Breastfeeding Association

breastfeeding.asn.au

Trusted support on nutrition and hydration while breastfeeding (Foundation 7).

Guidelines are updated over time; the figures here reflect current Australian recommendations at the time of writing. Your own GP, dietitian or specialist can confirm what applies to you.

Support that's actually tailored to *you*.

None of this needs to be perfect. But if you'd like guidance built around your body, your stage and your real life, through fertility, pregnancy, or those early months as a mum, that's exactly what I do, over telehealth right across Australia.

You can book a free 15-minute callback. No pitch, no pressure, just a chat to see if I'm the right fit to help.

Book a free 15-minute chat

Kat xx

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This guide provides general information only and is not personal medical or nutrition advice. It does not diagnose, treat or replace individual care. Please consult your own dietitian, GP or specialist for guidance specific to your circumstances.